The More Excellent Way

Without love, even our greatest gifts and sacrifices count for nothing; love is patient, kind and lasting, because it reflects God himself.

Main passage	1 Corinthians 13:1-13 (KJV)
Topic	Love
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Without love, nothing else counts	7 min
Teaching point 2: Love is shown in how we treat people	7 min
Teaching point 3: Love never fails	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Most of us have heard this chapter read at weddings. Ask: "Where else in life do these verses need to be lived out?" (At home on a bad day, at work, in church business meetings, with difficult neighbours.) Explain that Paul first wrote these words to a quarrelling church, not to a bride and groom.

Scripture (3 min)

1 Corinthians 13:1-13

[1] Though I speak with the tongues of men and of angels, and have not charity, I am become as sounding brass, or a tinkling cymbal. [2] And though I have the gift of prophecy, and understand all mysteries, and all knowledge; and though I have all faith, so that I could remove mountains, and have not charity, I am nothing. [3] And though I bestow all my goods to feed the poor, and though I give my body to be burned, and have not charity, it profiteth me nothing. [4] Charity suffereth long, and is kind; charity envieth not; charity

vaunteth not itself, is not puffed up, [5] Doth not behave itself unseemly, seeketh not her own, is not easily provoked, thinketh no evil; [6] Rejoiceth not in iniquity, but rejoiceth in the truth; [7] Beareth all things, believeth all things, hopeth all things, endureth all things. [8] Charity never faileth: but whether there be prophecies, they shall fail; whether there be tongues, they shall cease; whether there be knowledge, it shall vanish away. [9] For we know in part, and we prophesy in part. [10] But when that which is perfect is come, then that which is in part shall be done away. [11] When I was a child, I spake as a child, I understood as a child, I thought as a child: but when I became a man, I put away childish things. [12] For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known. [13] And now abideth faith, hope, charity, these three; but the greatest of these is charity.

Read the passage aloud. Note that the King James Version uses "charity" for the Greek word agape; modern translations say "love."

Background (5 min)

The church in Corinth was gifted but divided. Chapters 12 and 14 deal with spiritual gifts, which some Corinthians were using to show off and to rank one another. Chapter 13 stands between them. Paul does not say the gifts are bad. He says that without love they are empty.

The old English word "charity" once meant love in its fullest sense, love for God and for others, not only giving to the poor. Adam Clarke points out that verse 3 shows this: a person could give away everything and still lack "charity."

> *"This is a proof that charity, in our sense of the word, is not what the apostle means"*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 1 Corinthians 13:3

Teacher note: Verses 8-10 ("tongues, they shall cease ... when that which is perfect is come") are read differently by Christians when it comes to spiritual gifts today; the church has a separate lesson on that question. For this lesson, keep the focus where Paul puts it: love outlasts every gift.

Teaching point 1: Without love, nothing else counts (7 min)

Paul names the most impressive things he can think of: speaking in every language, prophecy, knowledge, mountain-moving faith, giving everything away, even martyrdom. Without love, each one is just noise or nothing. God measures our lives not by how impressive they are but by how much love is in them.

Supporting verses

1 Corinthians 13:1-3: Though I speak with the tongues of men and of angels, and have not charity, I am become as sounding brass, or a tinkling cymbal. And though I have the gift of prophecy, and understand all mysteries, and all knowledge; and though I have all faith, so that I could remove mountains, and have not charity, I am nothing. And though I bestow all my goods to feed the poor, and though I give my body to be burned, and have not charity, it profiteth me nothing.

Matthew 22:37-40: Jesus said unto him, Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy mind. This is the first and great commandment. And the second is like unto it, Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself. On these two commandments hang all the law and the prophets.

1 John 4:7-8: Beloved, let us love one another: for love is of God; and every one that loveth is born of God, and knoweth God. He that loveth not knoweth not God; for God is love.

> *"Charity, or love to God and man, the sum and substance of all true religion"*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 1 Corinthians 13:1

Handout blanks (answers)

Without love, I am as sounding brass or a tinkling **cymbal**.

Without love, even great gifts profit me **nothing**.

Teaching point 2: Love is shown in how we treat people (7 min)

Verses 4-7 describe what love does, and it is very practical. It is patient and kind. It does not envy or boast, and it is not rude or self-seeking. It is not quickly angered and keeps no record of wrongs. Barnes notes that every description has to do with how we behave toward other people. A good exercise is to put your own name in place of "charity" and read the verses honestly.

Supporting verses

1 Corinthians 13:4-7: Charity suffereth long, and is kind; charity envieth not; charity vaunteth not itself, is not puffed up, Doth not behave itself unseemly, seeketh not her own, is not easily provoked, thinketh no evil; Rejoiceth not in iniquity, but rejoiceth in the truth; Beareth all things, believeth all things, hopeth all things, endureth all things.

Romans 12:9-10: Let love be without dissimulation. Abhor that which is evil; cleave to that which is good. Be kindly affectioned one to another with brotherly love; in honour preferring one another;

Colossians 3:12-14: Put on therefore, as the elect of God, holy and beloved, bowels of mercies, kindness, humbleness of mind, meekness, longsuffering; Forbearing one another, and forgiving one another, if any man have a quarrel against any: even as Christ forgave you, so also do ye. And above all these things put on charity, which is the bond of perfectness.

> *"His illustrations are all drawn from its effect in regulating our conduct towards others, or our intercourse with them."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on 1 Corinthians 13:4

> *"Love makes allowances for the falls of others"*
> — Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on 1 Corinthians 13:5

Handout blanks (answers)

Love suffers long and is **kind**.

Love is seen in how we **treat** other people.

Teaching point 3: Love never fails (7 min)

Gifts are for this life. One day we will see God "face to face" (v. 12), and partial knowledge will give way to full knowledge. Faith and hope matter now, but love is the greatest, because God is love and love will last forever. Investing in love is investing in what lasts.

Supporting verses

1 Corinthians 13:8-13 (read from the Bible)

1 John 4:16: And we have known and believed the love that God hath to us. God is love; and he that dwelleth in love dwelleth in God, and God in him.

Romans 8:38-39: For I am persuaded, that neither death, nor life, nor angels, nor principalities, nor powers, nor things present, nor things to come, Nor height, nor depth, nor any other creature, shall be able to separate us from the love of God, which is in Christ Jesus our Lord.

> *"This love never falleth off, because it bears, believes, hopes, and endures all things"*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 1 Corinthians 13:8

> *"It is valuable, and is to be sought, because it will always abide"*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on 1 Corinthians 13:8

Handout blanks (answers)

Charity never **faileth (fails)**.

The greatest of faith, hope and charity is **charity (love)**.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. Why do you think Paul put this chapter in the middle of a discussion about spiritual gifts?

Because the Corinthians were using gifts to compete; Paul shows that love must govern every gift.

2. Read verses 4-7 with your own name in place of "charity." Which line is hardest to say truthfully?

Answers will vary; encourage honesty rather than embarrassment.

3. Love "thinketh no evil" (v. 5) and keeps no record of wrongs. How is that different from ignoring wrongdoing?

It means not storing up grudges or assuming the worst; it does not mean calling evil good or refusing to address real harm.

4. Why is love greater than faith and hope?

Faith and hope serve us in this life until we see God; love is the life of heaven itself and reflects God's own nature.

Application (3 min)

Choose one line from verses 4-7 that you most need. Write it on a card and carry it with you. Each evening this week, ask: "Where did I practice this today, and where did I fail?" Then thank God for his love that never fails you.

Closing prayer (2 min)

God of love, you loved us first and sent your Son for us. Forgive us for gifts used without love and words spoken without kindness. Make us patient, kind and humble. Teach us to keep no record of wrongs, and fill us with the love that never fails. In Jesus' name, Amen.

Sources quoted

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 1 Corinthians 13:3

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 1 Corinthians 13:1

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on 1 Corinthians 13:4

Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on 1 Corinthians 13:5

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 1 Corinthians 13:8

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